

moves. Black will challenge in the centre with ...c7-c6 or ...e7-e6 (or both) and does not mind if White attacks the knight again with f2-f4 as this will further loosen his position.

7...a6

7...e5? would be a mistake as after 8 d5 the knight on c6 has no active square. Whilst this central strike is very much part of Black's thinking, he must wait for the optimum moment. This usually means delaying until the knight on e2 has moved away. Then the black knight will be able to jump into d4 when White plays d5

7...a6 may look like a strange non-developing move but it is an essential component in Black's deep plan. His thinking is along the following lines: White is planning to launch an attack on the kingside and if he does this he is going to want to castle queenside. Therefore, I'd better make sure that the queenside is a hostile environment for his king. This means that I'll have to be ready to play ...b7-b5 to open lines in this part of the board. So let's play ...a7-a6 and ...Rb8 and see if he still dares to castle.

8 Qd2 Rb8 (Diagram 11)

This is the basic starting position of The Panno. White's natural developing moves have now been exhausted so it is decision time. Does he start a kingside attack knowing that Black will be able to counter-attack on the queenside or does he choose a more circumspect plan? This is mainly a question of style. If you revel in do or die tactical battles then 9 h4 is the move for you. This is examined in Games 32 and 33. If you don't wish to burn your boats then 9 Nc1 is the main alternative. This is covered in Game 34.

Theoretical?

The play can be extremely sharp but there is no need to learn everything off by heart. It is more important to understand the methods of attacking as the details are always going to be different.

Statistics

White has scored just 51% from 2831 games. Better than against 6...c5 but still well below the average. My comments about the Samisch looking like an imperial variation that is slightly over the hill are beginning to seem quite appropriate. I wrote that before I checked the statistics.

Illustrative Games

Game 32

□ Rivas ■ Mestel

Marbella 1982

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 f3 0-0 6 Be3 a6 7 Qd2 Nc6 8

Nge2 Rb8 9 h4 h5

Black spends a tempo to hold up the advance of White's h-pawn. This is the main line. In the past the positions after 9...e5 10 d5 Na5 11 Ng3 c5 12 h5 and 9...b5 10 h5 e5 11 d5 Na5 12 Ng3 were also extensively tested but the consensus now is that these lines favour White.

10 Bh6

10 0-0-0 is covered in the next game, while certain White players like to play 10 Nc1. Play is identical to Game 34 except for the inclusion of the moves h2-h4 and ...h7-h5. It is difficult to say whom this favours but some of the differences are pointed out within Game 34.

After 10 Bh6 Black has an important decision to make. Should he let White exchange bishops on g7 or should he capture himself on h6.

The latter looks foolhardy as it brings the white queen to an extremely menacing position. However, it also draws it away from the defence of the white queenside, and in particular the b2-square. See the next game for an example of Black exchanging on h6.

10...b5

Black starts his attack.

11 Bxg7 Kxg7 12 0-0-0 e5

12...bxc4 is obviously an alternative. After 13 Nf4 it is probably not a good idea for Black to try and hang on to the pawn with 13...Na5 because of the reply 14 e5. Instead he should play 13...e5.

13 dxe5

Better than blocking the centre. Black can meet 13 d5 with 13...Na5.

13...Nxe5

13...dxe5 14 Qe3! followed by Nd5 promises White a small advantage.

14 cxb5 axb5 15 Nf4 b4 16 Ncd5 Nxd5 17 Nxd5 c5 18 f4 Nc6 19 f5! (Diagram 12)

A pawn on f6 supported by the knight on d5 is a potent force.

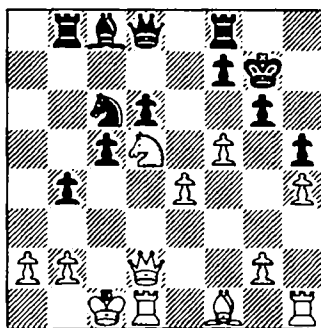


Diagram 12
White begins his attack

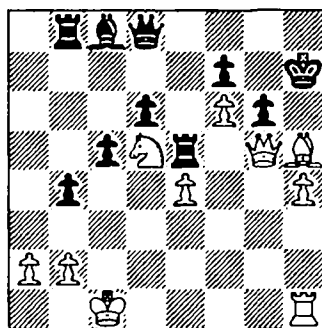


Diagram 13
What now for White?

19...Ne5 20 g4! Nxf4 21 Be2 Nf2?

He should have played 21...Nf6 although White is better after 22 Qf4'.

22 f6+ Kh7 23 Bxh5! Nxh1 24 Rxh1 Re8

After 24...gxh5 25 Qg5 Black is either mated by Qg7 or Qxh5.

25 Qg5! Re5 (Diagram 13)

Black was relying on this move to repulse the attack.

26 Ne7!!

There is nothing like a queen sacrifice to make the chessplayer's pulse race. The black king is now caught in a mating net

26...Qg8

The main line of the combination was 26...Rxc5 27 hxc5 Qxe7 (27...gxh5 28 Rxh5 mate and on other moves White moves the bishop away with checkmate) 28 fxg7 when the passed pawn decides the game. For example, 28...Be6 29 Bd1+! Kg8 30 Ba4.

27 Bd1!

White is certainly not sidetracked by 27 Nxc5? Rxc5 28 hxc5 Kxc8. After the bishop retreat the threat is 28 h5! Rxc5 29 hxc6 mate.

27...Kh8 28 Qh6+ Black resigns

It's mate in 3.

Game 33

□ Muir ■ Fedorov

European Team Championship, Batumi 1999

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 f3 0-0 6 Nge2 a6 7 Bg5 Nc6 8 Qd2 Rb8 9 h4 h5 10 0-0-0 b5 11 Bh6 Bxh6 12 Qxh6 e5 13 d5?! (Diagram 14)

This looks like a mistake as the black attack is the quicker. How do you think Black was planning to meet 13 g4? (Diagram 14)

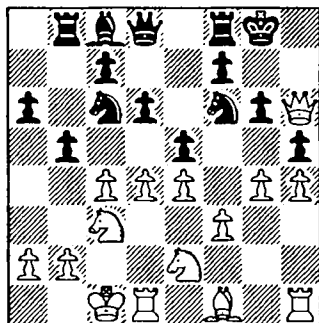


Diagram 14

How should Black respond?

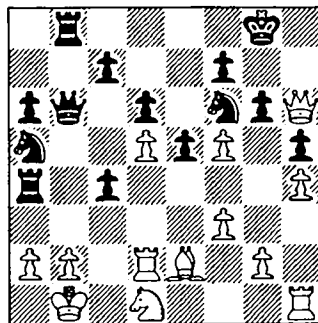


Diagram 15

What now for Black?